

FASHION ICON

MARIE-ANTOINETTE

When the Austrian-born Marie-Antoinette (1755–1793) arrived in France in 1770, she was handed over to the Bourbon court and stripped naked. Relinquishing her Austrian nationality along with her clothes, she was dressed in a gleaming ceremonial gown. She was to marry the dauphin, Louis Auguste, the future King Louis XVI of France, and give the kingdom an heir. At first she played the dutiful wife, but struggled to fit in with Versailles' rigid idea of royal glamour: vast pannier skirts (undergarments worn wide at the sides, but flat at the front and rear) and whalebone corsets. Friendless, childless, and viewed with suspicion by a hostile French court, she turned to costume as a strategy for survival and to bolster her prestige. One disapproving aristocrat remarked that she had staged a "veritable revolution in fashion".

Extravagance and experimentation

Marie-Antoinette confounded expectations of a royal consort. In a scandalous move, she refused to wear the posture-enhancing corset. After learning to ride, she abandoned the long, flowing skirts of a side-saddle rider and wore male breeches and a riding coat, drawing swift condemnation. Her mother warned: "If you are riding like a man, dressed as a man...I have to tell you that I find it dangerous as well as bad for bearing children..."

In 1774, when her husband Louis XVI was crowned King of France, all eyes were on Marie-Antoinette and her new "pouf" hairstyle. Heavily powdered hair was teased high above the forehead and topped with a cluster of white ostrich feathers. It was a look soon emulated by all of French society.

The queen experimented with eye-catching ensembles. She made weekly trips to Paris to meet the city's most famous designers. Rose Bertin (1747–1813), originally a fabric seller, became her most trusted stylist. In 1780 her provocative *robe à la polonoise*, with a bosom-enhancing bodice and ankle-baring skirt, soon caught on. Instead of having panniers, gowns once again had bunched fabric at the back. Sleeves remained elbow-length, but were tight-fitting and edged with a frill. The new "Polonoise" style was adopted simultaneously by the French and English courts.

Simplicity and star quality

By the mid- to late 1780s Marie-Antoinette had changed style completely. She offended her French compatriots by adopting Anglophile fashions, wearing much simpler, lighter dresses. As her look softened, she outraged courtiers by wearing thin, muslin *chemises à la reine* loosely belted at the waist. Without panniers, the fabric moulded around the legs. The peasant-girl look was topped with a broad straw hat, tilted at every imaginable angle. It was a trend condemned by French society but soon copied. Through her dress, Marie-Antoinette conveyed total power, a queen who wore whatever she wanted, no matter the cost. Her enemies at court spread rumours of her financial irresponsibility and addiction to fashion, and in revolutionary France her outfits came to symbolize a betrayal of the people. Marie-Antoinette rode to her death in 1793 wearing a brand new white chemise she had secretly saved.

A trendsetter whose style had been copied by commoners and courtiers alike, Marie-Antoinette was a queen of fashion to the very end.



△ **THE YOUNG MARIE-ANTOINETTE**
In this portrait painted when she was 12, the Archduchess Marie-Antoinette is shown as perfection personified.



△ THE PANNIER GOWN

The epitome of exaggerated style, the material of Marie-Antoinette's dress is heavily laden with lace. Wide panniers, often up to 3.5m (12ft) wide, typified the style of dress required at court when Marie-Antoinette first became queen.

TIMELINE

1770 Brings Austrian fashion to the French court, but is made to wear the traditional corsets and heavy dresses of the royal court

▷ **Early 1770s**
Refuses to wear a corset and dons outrageous androgynous riding habits

1774 Stuns the court with her new "pouf" hairstyle

◁ **Late 1770s** Her extravagant dresses repeatedly cause a stir

1780 Introduces the much-copied "Polonoise" dress, bringing the "bustle look" back in vogue and baring the ankles

Late 1780s Adopts simple dresses and rustic attire, rebelling against strictures of Versailles

◁ **1788** Poses with her young children in a softer dress, showing her maternal side



◁ **A SUITABLE PORTRAIT** This 1783 portrait, showing the queen clad in silk, swiftly replaced an earlier portrait of her posing in her muslin *chemise à la reine*, which had caused an outcry.